

Practice Paper 37 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — The grandmother’s usual way of communicating

1 mark for understanding that her messages were **very short**; **1 mark** for the suggestion that they were **almost rude / blunt / not softened by politeness**.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that her grandmother used as **few words as possible** and did not bother with the usual polite softeners, so her messages could feel **blunt or even curt** to those who received them.

Q2. [2] — “A debt that one is, sooner or later, asked to repay”

1 mark — The narrator regrets having **taken her grandmother for granted** / having assumed there would be many more such afternoons.

1 mark — She now realises, **with hindsight**, that this casual assumption **cost her something** — the afternoon turned out to be precious, and she did not value it properly at the time.

Q3. [2] — The grandmother had prepared carefully

1 mark each for any two of:

- The pot was **already warm** / sitting on the back of the stove, lid tilted, “breathing out the first thin curl of steam”.
- The seven spices stood in “**a long disciplined row**” in small bowls, ready in order.
- The ginger had already been knotted, the garlic “**broken into cloves**”, the salt portioned out — everything had been pre-measured.
- She was **already wearing** her familiar apron.

Q4. [2] — “The way another woman might have announced a marriage”

1 mark — The comparison suggests that the grandmother treated the recipe as something **enormously important / solemn / ceremonial**.

1 mark — It also suggests that, for her, **passing the recipe on** was as significant a **life event** as a wedding — a formal joining of one generation to the next.

Q5. [2] — “She said that less often now”

(a) [1]: It quietly suggests that the grandmother is **aware her memory / health is no longer reliable**, and that she may not have much more time to pass the recipe on.

(b) [1]: The writer **understates** the idea to preserve **dignity** and to match the grandmother’s own restraint — saying it openly would make the moment sentimental, whereas hinting at it allows the reader to **feel** the truth without it being declared.

Q6. [3] — Cooking as a living, human event

1 mark for identifying **personification** of the food / cooking; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- The cumin “**muttered and darkened**” — the verb **muttered** suggests low human speech, as though the spices are talking back.
- The kitchen “**filled, in three quick breaths**” — the kitchen itself seems to breathe, like a living body.
- The smell was so familiar that it made her **eyes sting** — the cooking provokes an almost emotional human response.
- The grandmother “**handed us a small, fragile object across a table**” — the instructions are treated as physical, living things being carried carefully.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — What the grandmother chose **not** to say

1 mark — She **trusts** Lina, and does not want to **undermine** her with anxious warnings.

1 mark — Her silence also shows **respect** — she is treating Lina as a proper cook, not as a child, and giving her the **dignity** of being allowed to make her own mistakes.

Q8. [1] — “Folded her hands in front of her apron and watched”

1 mark — The detail suggests **quiet acceptance / peace / contentment**: she has **deliberately stepped back** and is willing to **let go** of control, observing with calm rather than with anxiety. (Also accept: she is **passing the torch** / gently letting Lina take charge.)

Q9. [1] — The family understood the importance of the afternoon

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- The aunt was **writing everything down in tiny careful handwriting** on the back of an envelope.
- The mother had **gone very still** in the doorway.
- **No one looked at their phones** for the whole afternoon.
- The grandmother’s hands rested **very lightly** on the counter, as if grateful for it (also accepted).

Q10. [2] — Mood at the table

1 mark — The family were eating **unhurriedly, with full attention** — savouring the food rather than rushing.

1 mark — There was a **quiet awareness** (a tenderness, even sadness) that **this particular occasion would not happen again**, or that the curry, made by the grandmother alone, would never be made in quite the same way again.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, tender, grateful, quietly grieving, accepting, bittersweet**.
(Reject: **cheerful, bitter** — these miss the gentle, accepting quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Not gradual but headlong”

1 mark for understanding **gradual** — slow, steady, taking place over a long period.

1 mark for understanding **headlong** — extremely rapid, almost reckless, as though falling forwards.

Together: the decline of letter-writing has been **unusually swift** — not a slow drift but an **abrupt collapse** within a single generation.

Q13. [2] — Why texts and emails appear to have replaced letters

1 mark each for any two of:

- A text message is **free** / costs nothing.
- It **arrives in seconds** (i.e. is almost instant).
- It **demand**s **very little** of the sender (it is easy and effortless).
- An email can be **sent to many recipients at once** without extra cost.
- Letters require **paper, postage**, and the **long wait** for delivery.

Q14. [1] — “Deserves more careful examination”

1 mark — The writer is suggesting that the **obvious conclusion may not be the whole truth** — that, although texts are faster and cheaper, letters offer **something valuable** that the new technology **cannot replace**, and we should think harder before accepting their loss.

Q15. [2] — Why letters are “kinder” than texts

1 mark — Because writing a letter **takes time**, the writer is **forced to pause and think** before committing words to the page.

1 mark — The slow process **outlives strong emotions** such as anger or irritation, so the final letter is usually **gentler and more considered** than a text dashed off on impulse.

Q16. [2] — The Lucy Mangan quotation

1 mark — The quotation provides **expert support** / a memorable illustration of the writer’s claim that letters are kinder than texts.

1 mark — It cleverly **implies the mechanism**: the slowness of letter-writing **gives anger time to fade** before the letter is finished, so harsh words are revised or never sent.

Q17. [2] — “Their richest subjects almost mute”

1 mark — The **most interesting and important people** of our time will leave behind **very little written record** of their thoughts and lives.

1 mark — Historians of the future will find it **almost impossible to “hear”** these people in their own words, because most of their conversations took place in fragile digital form that no longer exists.

Q18. [2] — “The ceremony of attention”

(a) [1]: The phrase suggests that writing a letter is an act of **undivided, focused attention** given to one named person — a **quiet, almost sacred** moment of single-minded concentration.

(b) [1]: The word **ceremony** is effective because it elevates an everyday act into something **formal, deliberate, and meaningful** — it treats the recipient with the **dignity and respect** that a ritual would imply.

Q19. [2] — Evidence letter-writing may be returning

1 mark each for any two of:

- School **penpal schemes** have been **revived** in many countries.
- “**Slow-mail**” **smartphone apps** deliberately delay messages and have attracted **hundreds of thousands** of users.
- **Stationery sales** have begun **creeping upwards** again.
- Sales of **writing paper to under-thirties** grew by **eighteen per cent** in 2024 (one British retailer).

Q20. [1] — “Gone underground”

1 mark — The word **underground** suggests that the appetite for letter-writing has **not died** but has **retreated quietly out of public view** — it is **hidden but still alive**, waiting to be noticed again. (Also accept: it has become a **small, almost secret** practice rather than a mainstream one.)

Q21. [2] — “A small, deliberate refusal”

1 mark — The word **refusal** suggests **active resistance** — writing a letter is not merely a habit but a **conscious rejection** of the dominant culture of speed.

1 mark — It is effective because it **empowers** an apparently small act, giving the reader a sense that each letter is a **deliberate choice** against the rush of modern communication, however quiet.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

What is being lost as letter-writing disappears (Paragraphs 3–5):

1. **Slowness** — the writer is forced to **think carefully** before committing words to the page.
2. Letters are therefore **kinder / more considered** — strong emotions such as anger fade before the letter is finished.
3. **Archival value** — letters are **durable** and survive for generations, allowing historians to reconstruct lives.
4. By contrast, **digital messages are fragile** and can vanish with a deleted account or a forgotten password.
5. **Undivided attention** — writing a letter means doing **one thing**, for **one named person**, free of distractions.

Small movements keeping the practice alive (Paragraph 6):

6. **School penpal schemes** have been revived to link children across cultures or generations.

7. **“Slow-mail” apps** that deliberately delay messages have attracted **hundreds of thousands** of users.
8. **Stationery sales** are **rising again**, especially among **younger buyers**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

As letter-writing fades, what is being lost is the slowness that forces writers to think carefully, producing kinder words once anger has cooled. We also lose durable records: letters survive for centuries, while digital messages can vanish overnight, leaving future historians with little. Worst of all, we lose the rare, undivided attention given to one named reader. Yet penpal schemes, deliberately delayed message apps, and rising stationery sales among young buyers suggest the appetite quietly endures.

Length count: 78 words from “As” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —